

# Functional Ecology

*Authors*

21–26 minutes

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This page is intended for authors planning their initial submission to the journal. Authors who have been asked to prepare a revision should [click here](#). For initial submission, we do not require you to adhere to journal formatting requirements. Please see our quick checklist for initial submission for details. **Please ensure that your article fits within the journal's [Aims and Scope](#) and that you have read our [Editorial Policies](#) before submitting your article.**

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[For information on post-acceptance processes \(including open access options\) click here.](#)

## **Editorial Process – double-anonymous peer review**

**After 3 years, the data has been analysed and the results of the trial are available to read [here](#)!**

### **Key takeaway:**

"The double-anonymous peer review trial indicates reviewer bias is reduced when author identities are anonymised: when reviewers did not know whose paper they were reviewing, peer review outcomes were similar across author

demographics; in contrast, when reviewers did know whose paper they were reviewing (e.g. double-anonymous peer review), papers with first authors residing in higher-income countries and in countries with higher English proficiency were favored. Interestingly, anonymising author details had no effect on gender differences in reviewer ratings or editor decisions."

**Based on the results of this trial, Functional Ecology has now transitioned to mandatory double-anonymous peer review.** [Click here for more information on the trial and the results.](#)

## Quick Checklist for Initial Submission

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To simplify the process for authors we differentiate between initial and revised submissions. Initial submissions can be submitted in any file type providing they adhere to the following requirements. More details are included below this checklist. All manuscripts should take care not to obviously identify the authors in the main text and supporting information. E.g. instead of saying ‘in our previous study’ please say ‘in a previous study by ref et al’. Papers that include text that clearly identifies the authors may be returned for revision before being considered for publication.

- A **title page** submitted as a separate ‘title page’ file containing the **manuscript title; author names, institutions and addresses; acknowledgements, author contributions** ([see authorship policy](#)), [data availability statement](#), [data sources](#) ([where appropriate](#)).
- Include line and page numbers.
- Text should be in a single column with at least 1.5 line spacing.
- Research papers must follow standard manuscript structure: **Abstract** (must be numbered according to journal style), **Keywords, Introduction, Materials and Methods** (including **replication statement**), **Results, Discussion, Conclusions** (optional), **References, Figures and Tables with captions**.
- Figures and Tables can be embedded within the text where referenced to facilitate reviewing.

- The journal does not impose hard word limits but research articles, reviews and perspectives over 7,500 words (including tables, references and figure legends) must justify the length and authors should give a brief (one or two sentence) explanation in their cover letter. Commentaries have a limit of 4,000. Papers that fail to make good use of their word counts and are unnecessarily long will likely be declined by the editors.

## Article types

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## Research Article

See [Manuscript Specifications](#) below for formatting requirements.

## Review

Functional Ecology publishes integrative or synthetic review papers that go beyond a summary of the literature to synthesise the current state of the knowledge on a timely subject and advance the area of research. Our reviews are generally concise (~7500 words) and should be written in a manner that makes them accessible to readers outside the immediate field. Reviews should be question-focused (not taxon-focused) and on subjects of broad ecological interest. Please refer to this [editorial](#) for more explanation on the type of review papers we aim to publish. If you have written a review that falls within Functional Ecology's remit and will be of broad general interest, please submit your review to the journal, noting in your letter to the editor how your review fits into the broader literature (i.e., how it relates to similar recently-published reviews) and how it advances the broader field of ecology.

***Pre-submission enquiries:*** If you have an idea for a review, please submit your query to our Reviews Editor, [Liza Holeski](#) (cc to [admin@functionalecology.org](mailto:admin@functionalecology.org)). You should send a short description of the proposed topic and a brief statement about why it is relevant to readers of Functional Ecology. We can provide more meaningful feedback if your query includes a summary or outline, with a clear description of the aims of the review and how it relates to other review papers published in recent years. We strongly encourage authors to provide a diagram or

conceptual figure showing the how the topics covered in the text contribute to the overall aims of the review.

Reviews should have informative subject headings, dependent on the topic of the paper, and do not need to adhere to research article format. See **this [editorial](#) and [recent review papers](#)** for further details and examples.

## **Commentary**

These are short communications (usually up to 4000 words) on a topical subject of interest to our readership.

## **Perspective**

These are short, forward-looking articles presenting new ideas (without data) intended to stimulate scientific debate. A Perspective can be speculative or from a personal viewpoint, but should also be evidence-based and clearly demonstrate the reasoning behind the speculation.

## **Forum**

Forums are short communications presenting opinions on, or responses to, material published in the journal. Reanalysis of data presented in the focal article is encouraged, but new data should not generally be presented. Forums should be submitted within 12 months of publication of the original article. If accepted, they will be held from publication while the authors of the original article are invited to respond. If factual errors in the original article come to light, these will be investigated before publication of the Forum article and a correction notice may be published either instead of or as well as the Forum article. Functional Ecology does not publish manuscripts whose primary purpose is to critique papers published in other journals.

## **Research Highlights (FE Spotlights)**

Functional Ecology Spotlights are short invited commentaries, highlighting papers of exceptional quality and significant novelty. These commentaries place the research in context and highlight how the paper advances ecology.

# Manuscript Specifications

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**All research articles should be submitted ready for double-anonymized peer review with a separate title page and with all obviously identifiable reference to authors removed.** Manuscripts should be double line-spaced with continuous

line numbers throughout the article. Manuscripts must be written in English.

Authors for whom English is not their first language may wish to consider using a professional editing service before submission. We are currently offering a trial of

[Writefull](#), which authors can use free of charge. Writefull screens your text for correctness of grammar, spelling, vocabulary, punctuation, style, word order, phrasing, and more. In order to use Writefull, [please contact the Editorial Office for a single-use URL](#) to use for your paper, or you can request access during the submission process. When you receive a Writefull link, the Editorial Office will return your paper to you so you can implement any suggested changes before your paper goes to the Editor. Alternatively you may want to use [Wiley's editing services](#). The use of these services does not guarantee acceptance or preference for publication. It is also recommended that authors follow search engine optimisation guidelines to [maximise the reach of their article](#).

All abstracts should be written in English, However, we encourage authors to provide a second abstract in their native language or the language relevant to the country in which the research was conducted. The second abstract will be published with the online version of the article and will not be included in the PDF. Second abstracts will not be copyedited and will be published as provided by the authors. Authors who wish to take advantage of this option should provide the second abstract in the main document below the English language version.

Submissions should be divided into the following sections:

## Title page

The title page must be uploaded as a separate file from the main manuscript and should contain the following:

- A concise and informative title. Do not include the authorities for taxonomic names.

- A list of all authors' names with names and addresses of institutions.
- The name, address and e-mail address of the corresponding author
- **Acknowledgements (optional)** - A brief statement acknowledging collaborators and research assistants who do not meet the criteria for authorship described above, or acknowledging funding sources, providing relevant permit numbers (including institutional animal use permits), or giving recognition to nature reserves or other organizations that made the work possible.
- **Conflict of Interest (required for all article types)**  
 All authors are required to disclose any potential sources of conflict of interest. Any interest or relationship, financial or otherwise, that might be perceived as influencing an author's objectivity is considered a potential source of conflict of interest. These must be disclosed when directly relevant or indirectly related to the work described in the manuscript. Potential sources of conflict of interest include but are not limited to patent or stock ownership, employment by a private company or non-profit organisation, membership of a company board of directors, membership of an advisory board or committee for a company, and consultancy for or receipt of speaker's fees from a company. The existence of a conflict of interest does not preclude publication in the journal. If the authors have no conflicts of interest, this should be stated within this section. See our full [Conflict of Interest policy](#) for more information.
- **Author Contributions** - All submissions with more than one author must include an Author Contributions statement. All persons listed as authors on a paper are expected to meet ALL of the following criteria for authorship:
  - substantial contributions to conception and design, or acquisition of data, or analysis and interpretation of data, or drafting the article or revising it critically for important intellectual content;
  - final approval of the version to be published;
  - agreement to be accountable for the aspects of the work that they conducted and ensuring that questions related to the accuracy or integrity of any part of their work are appropriately investigated and resolved.

Submissions with more than one author must include an Authors Contributions statement explaining the contribution of each author. Each author must be

mentioned by name. If you would like to use the CRediT taxonomy you are welcome to do so. We suggest the following format:

[Name of Author 1] and [Name of Author 3] conceived the ideas and designed methodology; [Name of Author 1] and [Name of Author 2] collected the data; [Name of Author 1] and [Name of Author 3] analysed the data; [Name of Author 1] and [Name of Author 2] led the writing of the manuscript. All authors contributed critically to the drafts and gave final approval for publication.

Acquisition of funding, provision of facilities, or supervising the research group of authors without additional contribution (as listed above) are not sufficient justifications for authorship. Such contributions can be listed in the Acknowledgements, but should not be included in the Author Contributions Statement.

- **Statement on inclusion** (optional within the Author Contributions statement in published article, but required during submission)

In order to support more global representation in ecology, authors are encouraged to include a statement within the author contributions section that discloses the actions that were taken during the study to collaborate with, provide opportunities for intellectual input, and share outcomes with stakeholders within the region where the study was conducted. Please see Journal of Applied Ecology's [Editorial](#) for more information on the rationale behind this and other related initiatives.

*Example statements (for guidance only):*

- Our study was a global review and was based on a meta-analysis of secondary data rather than primary data. As such, there was no local data collection. However, the geographical distribution of the authorship team broadly represents the major regions of interest in the meta-analysis, supporting the inclusion of data from peer-reviewed studies published in local languages and ensuring the appropriate interpretation of data and results from each region
- Our study brings together authors from a number of different countries, including scientists based in the country where the study was carried out. All authors were engaged early on with the research and study design to ensure that the diverse sets of perspectives they represent was considered from the onset. Whenever relevant,



literature published by scientists from the region was cited; efforts were made to consider relevant work published in the local language.

- Our study brings together authors from a number of different countries but failed to include scientists based in the country where the study was carried out. Attempts to identify local researchers whose expertise and skills were relevant to this project were made, but these efforts ended up being unfruitful due to the scarcity of scientists working in the region and the lack of capacity for those who do to engage in new collaborations. Whenever possible, our research was discussed with local stakeholders to seek feedback on the questions to be tackled and the approach to be considered. Whenever relevant, literature published by scientists from the region was also cited; efforts were made to consider relevant work published in the local language.
- Our study fails to include scientists based in the country where the study was carried out. We recognize that more could have been done to engage local scientists with our research as our project developed, and to embed our research within the national context and research priorities. We are planning to address these caveats in future research
- **Data availability statement** - To enable readers to locate archived data from papers, we require that authors list the database and the respective accession numbers or DOIs for all data from the manuscript that has been made publicly available (for example, “[Data available from the Dryad Digital Repository: https://doi.org/10.1111/1365-2656.12537](https://doi.org/10.1111/1365-2656.12537) (Kiere & Drummond 2016))”. When a DOI is available for the data, the full data citation should also be given in the reference list (see below).  
Please see our [editorial policies page](#) for further information on data archiving.

## **Main manuscript**

All manuscripts should take care not to obviously identify the authors in the main text and supporting information. E.g. instead of saying ‘in our previous study’ please say ‘in a previous study by ref et al’. Figures and tables can be embedded within the manuscript or uploaded separately. This should include the following sections:



- **Abstract** - The Abstract should not exceed 350 words and should list the main results and conclusions, using simple, factual, numbered statements.
- **Keywords** - A list in alphabetical order not exceeding eight words or short phrases. More [advice on selecting good keywords can be found here](#).
- **Introduction** - This should state the reason for doing the work, the nature of the hypothesis or hypotheses under consideration, and should outline the essential background.
- **Materials and methods** - Include sufficient details for the work to be repeated. A replication statement must be included (see below for more details)
- **Results** - State the results and draw attention in the text to important details shown in tables and figures.
- **Discussion** - This should point out the significance of the results in relation to the reasons for doing the work, and place them in the context of other work.
- **Conclusions (optional)**
- **References** - In-text citations should follow the author-date method whereby the author's last name and the year of publication for the source should appear in the text, for example, (Jones, 1998). The complete reference list should appear alphabetically by name at the end of the paper. Please note that a DOI should be provided for all references where available. You will not be asked to reformat references during submission or peer review however, a sample of the most common entries in our reference lists appears [here](#).
- **Data sources (where appropriate)** - Authors of submissions that use data from multiple published sources (e.g. if the paper describes a meta-analysis) should to cite these data sources in the main text of the manuscript or include a separate Data Sources section as appropriate. This ensures that these references are fully indexed and their authors are given proper citation credit.

Data sources can be cited in the “Materials and methods” or in the “Data availability” sections. If a large number of data sources are used, instead of citing the sources individually, a separate list should be provided after the literature reference list under the heading “Data sources”. The Material and methods section should then refer to this section, i.e. “A list of data sources used in the study are

provided in the Data sources section.”

Data from articles published in journals or data with a DOI should follow the normal journal citation format. Citation of datasets without a DOI is permitted, provided the data repository meets the standards set out in our Data Archiving policy. They should be formatted as above but should provide the permanent repository link and accession number for the data.

## Replication Statement

Before the description of data analyses in the Materials and Methods section, authors must state (as a table): i) the scale at which they seek to make inferences (for example at the level of species, populations or experimental units); ii) the scale(s) at which their treatment or factor of interest is (are) applied; and iii) the number of replicates for each level of treatment or factor (see table below). For more information on why we are requiring this and examples of these tables in practice, please see this [blogpost](#). Manuscripts without this table will be returned to authors. Please note that "theory only" papers do **not** require a replication statement.

| Scale of inference | Scale at which the factor of interest is applied | Number of replicates at the appropriate scale |
|--------------------|--------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| X                  | X                                                | X                                             |
| X                  | X                                                | X                                             |
|                    |                                                  |                                               |

## Supporting Information (optional)

For peer review supporting information should be anonymised in the same way as the main manuscript. Note that the BES does not allow data sets to be uploaded as Supporting Information. All relevant data must be archived in accordance with the [BES data archiving policy](#).

## Manuscript Submission

You can log in to our [submission system here](#).

All correspondence should be routed via the Assistant Editor, [Francis Harris](#).

During submission, authors will be asked to confirm that:

- The work as submitted has not been published or accepted for publication, nor is being considered for publication elsewhere, either in whole or substantial part.
- All authors and relevant institutions have read the submitted version of the manuscript and approve its submission.
- All persons entitled to authorship have been so included.
- The work is original and all necessary acknowledgements have been made.
- The work conforms to the legal requirements of the country in which it was carried out, including those relating to conservation and welfare, and to the journal's policy on these matters.
- Research articles will be included in the double-anonymized peer review trial and the submission has been appropriately anonymized.
- Third party data sets used in this work are either publicly available for unrestricted reuse or permission for reuse has been obtained from the data owners.

All co-authors will receive confirmation of submission.

Covering letters are optional and should be used to provide additional information not present in the manuscript which is relevant for the editorial office or editors.

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- If you receive a provisional accept or minor revision decision, please upload your LaTeX and EPS source files at this stage. Support files should be designated as 'not for review'. A single .tar or .zip file containing all of your source files and a readme file should be uploaded. If you have used a .bib file to generate your

bibliography in LaTeX please do include this in your .tar/.zip archive along with the .bbl and .tex files; this will aid the typesetting process.

## **Option to transfer to Ecology and Evolution**

Rejected manuscripts may be offered the option of having the paper, along with any reviews, transferred for consideration by the Editors of *Ecology and Evolution*.

More details are provided on the [Editorial Policies](#) page.

## **Appeals**

Appeals should be sent to the editorial office ([admin@functionalecology.org](mailto:admin@functionalecology.org)). In order to assess your appeal, you must provide a justification (ideally no longer than one page). This document will be sent to the relevant editorial staff. Note that each submission is considered carefully at the first assessment and decisions to reject a manuscript are not taken lightly.